The Proposal

The big idea

The Proposal by Russian writer **Anton Chekhov** is a **one-act farce** (a comedy based on exaggerated, ridiculous situations). A young man comes to propose marriage but ends up quarrelling with the girl and her father over trivial matters. It mocks the materialism and quarrelsome nature of wealthy landowners.

Characters

Character	Traits
Stepan Stepanovitch Chubukov	A landowner, the father; hypocritical, quick-tempered, eager to marry off his daughter.
Natalya Stepanovna	His daughter, 25; argumentative, proud, but eager to marry.
Ivan Vassilevitch Lomov	A neighbouring landowner, 35; nervous, a **hypochondriac** (always imagines illnesses — palpitations, a numb foot, twitching eyebrow), quarrelsome.

Summary

1. **Lomov arrives** in evening dress. Chubukov suspects he has come to borrow money, but Lomov announces he has come to ask for **Natalya's hand**. Chubukov is delighted and embraces him, saying he has always loved him like a son.

2. **Lomov's reasons:** He is 35, which he calls a "critical age"; he needs a quiet, regular life; Natalya is a good housekeeper, not bad-looking and well educated.
3. **First quarrel — the Oxen Meadows:** Before Lomov can propose, he mentions that **"my Oxen Meadows"** touch her birchwoods. Natalya insists they belong to her family. The quarrel grows loud. Chubukov joins in, and both families' ancestors are insulted. Lomov leaves, clutching his heart.
4. **Natalya learns the truth:** When Chubukov tells her Lomov came to propose, she becomes hysterical and demands that he be brought back.
5. **Second quarrel — the dogs:** Natalya, trying to be friendly, talks about hunting. Lomov says his dog **Guess** is better than her family's dog **Squeezer**, who he claims is **overshot** (has a lower jaw shorter than the upper). The argument grows again; Chubukov joins in.
6. **The climax:** Lomov collapses in a faint. Chubukov thinks he is dead; when he recovers, Chubukov quickly makes them kiss and announces the engagement. Even as Chubukov calls for **champagne**, Natalya and Lomov start quarrelling again about the dogs.

WHY IT IS A FARCE

Exaggerated characters, silly quarrels over trivial issues, sudden changes of mood and slapstick (fainting, hysterics) are all features of farce.

Themes

- **Marriage as a deal:** Lomov and the Chubukovs see marriage as a practical arrangement for property and comfort, not love.
- **Materialism and pride:** a meadow worth little and a hunting dog become matters of family honour.
- **Irony:** a "proposal" turns into a quarrel; "love" ends in arguments.
- **Hypocrisy:** Chubukov praises Lomov as a son, then insults him in the quarrel, then praises him again.

WHO OWNS WHICH DOG

Guess is Lomov's dog; **Squeezer** is the Chubukovs' dog.

VOCABULARY FROM THE PLAY

Hypochondriac; palpitations; overshot; farce; "this is the beginning of family bliss" — Chubukov's ironic last remark.

Message and value points

- Small egos and trivial matters can ruin relationships.
- Marriage based only on convenience and property lacks true love.
- Satire on the upper-class Russian society of Chekhov's time.

LIKELY QUESTIONS

Why is the play a farce? Character sketches of Lomov/Chubukov/Natalya. What were the two quarrels about? How does Chubukov's attitude towards Lomov keep changing?

Quick recap

- Anton Chekhov; one-act farce.
- Lomov (35, hypochondriac) comes to propose to Natalya (25).
- Quarrel 1: Oxen Meadows. Quarrel 2: Guess vs Squeezer.
- Lomov faints, engagement announced, quarrel continues — "family bliss".

Practice questions

1. Why did Chubukov first think Lomov had come?
   (a) To propose (b) To borrow money (c) To buy land (d) To complain about dogs
2. The first quarrel was about
   (a) a dog (b) Lomov's health (c) the Oxen Meadows (d) Chubukov's grandfather
3. Which word best describes Lomov?
   (a) Calm (b) Brave (c) Generous (d) Hypochondriac
4. "Guess" and "Squeezer" are
   (a) two meadows (b) two servants (c) two hunting dogs (d) two horses
5. How old is Lomov?
   (a) 25 (b) 30 (c) 35 (d) 40
6. The Proposal is best described as
   (a) a tragedy (b) a farce (c) an epic (d) a mystery
7. How does the play end?
   (a) Lomov leaves for good (b) Natalya refuses the proposal (c) The couple is engaged but keeps quarrelling (d) Chubukov sells the meadows
8. Why does Lomov want to marry Natalya?
9. "The Proposal" is a satire on the materialistic attitude of the rich. Discuss.

Answers: 1. b 2. c 3. d 4. c 5. c 6. b 7. c 8. see notes 9. see notes